

Small Group Policy Project

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Across the nation, chronic absenteeism affects educational institutions at all levels, impacting the quality and effectiveness of the resources provided to students. To combat this issue, programs and policies are put into place to help keep students in school. From a district-level perspective, there are ways for parents and teachers to be more proactive in the student learning experience, ideally improving students' ability to succeed in school. By examining districts in both Dallas and New York, we aim to compare the effectiveness of programs that are parent-focused versus teacher-focused.

The NYC Success Mentor Corps (NYCSMC) specifically focuses on pairing students who are identified as “at risk” with adult mentors and teachers who are able to provide support and improve attendance. This is done through a variety of incentivization methods and rewards for students. Through assemblies, awards, competitions, and meet-and-greets, NYCSMC ensures that students receive the positive support they need to continue attending school (New York City Children’s Cabinet, 2024). In contrast, the Dallas ISD Parent Attendance Success Initiative (PASI) is an online course designed to help parents identify and address barriers that prevent students from going to school (Dallas Independent School District, n.d.). Parents of students who are recognized as at risk by the program's standards are asked to complete this free online course, which aims to target the root causes of absenteeism in Dallas ISD.

These programs have already shown significant promise. Students who participated in NYCSMC reportedly gained back an average of 13 school days, meaning more time spent in class MENTOR New York. (2024, June 9). The program also addressed patterns of absenteeism,

with a 7% increase in students leaving chronic absenteeism after participation (New York City Children's Cabinet, 2024). In comparison, the PASI program targeted parents of frequently absent students and, as a result, reduced chronic absenteeism by 4%. While data is still limited because the program is relatively new, these early benefits encouraged Dallas ISD to invest an additional \$5 million into PASI KERA News. (2025, December 19). However, it is important to note that PASI is not as directly impactful as the hands-on NYCSMC program. The New York program particularly benefits students from lower-income neighborhoods by giving them a strong support system within the school, whereas PASI often motivates high school students indirectly by helping parents ensure their children receive credit for their classes.

Due to its institutional nature, NYCSMC requires more staffing and resources within schools. Advisors, counselors, and teachers must be trained and designated to implement the policies and suggestions outlined in the program, which becomes the main barrier to adoption. In contrast, PASI is an online course already established by the district that may only require occasional updates. Aside from this, PASI does not require major resources or infrastructure to maintain its effectiveness. Given these factors, the "hands-off" nature of PASI may make it less impactful than NYCSMC. Although PASI's training program is required for some parents, the likelihood that it has a major impact on families is lower compared to the direct influence NYCSMC has on students within the classroom.

While both strategies have merit, they target different areas and bring different strengths. NYCSMC is a strong fit for districts where chronic absenteeism is tied to students needing role models and lacking strong adult connections. Its biggest strength is its focus on building long-term relationships. By partnering at-risk students with mentors who focus on their growth, hold regular check-ins, and even visit their homes, students are more likely to trust them and, as

a result, listen to them. When mentors encourage regular attendance and serve as positive role models, students become more motivated to attend classes and understand the value of school on a deeper level. However, mentoring programs require significant coordination and human resources, which makes them harder to scale broadly. Additionally, pairing mentors and students based on similar backgrounds or interests for maximum effectiveness adds another layer of complexity. Therefore, this program is especially effective in local areas where students may not regularly see strong role models, but it would be much harder to expand widely. On the other hand, PASI is a strong fit for districts where absenteeism is driven by family-level barriers such as transportation, scheduling, confusion about attendance rules, or a lack of information about school expectations. Because this is a free online truancy course, it is less personalized than individual mentoring and relies on external factors such as parents' ability to understand the content in English, have reliable internet access, and find the time to participate. While this course may work well in areas where parents are already involved in their child's education and have the capacity to support their success, it may have limited impact in areas where parents simply do not have the time to fully engage with the material. However, due to its digital nature, it is much easier to scale without requiring additional resources or extensive planning.

To ensure that students across all stages of absenteeism receive the proper intervention and support they need to achieve positive educational outcomes, we propose a hybrid model of PASI and NYCSMC. For students who are only infrequently absent, it is important to prevent further patterns of absenteeism. At this stage, PASI can instruct parents on the risks of chronic absenteeism and how to support their child in returning to school consistently. If a student begins skipping school more often, NYCSMC can provide mentorship that directly guides the student toward better educational habits. This program works best when a student needs personal

guidance to correct absenteeism behavior. For students who miss a significant portion of school and risk facing legal consequences, parents must be aware of the resources available to help their children return to good standing. In these cases, PASI can serve as a final support measure alongside an in-school mentor to quickly bring students back into regular attendance.

References

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